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For some time now, I'd been suffering from a plague of boils, like Job. They tended to be, more often than not, in or near the armpits,

4 See Through a Glass, Clearly (New English Library, 1967).

5 This is a supercommon situation now, but it was not so then. Sam's class may have been the first college class in science fiction.

and they made life very uncomfortable for me. I mentioned it to Dr. Ryan when I took David in for a routine injection. He gave me a penicillin shot and then questioned me closely on diabetes.

It hit home. After all, I had immersed myself in that biochemistry textbook and there was a whole chapter that dealt very largely with diabetes. One of the unpleasant side effects of the disease was a heightened tendency to infections such as boils. I said, "But my urine has been tested any number of times. There's never been any glucose in it."

He said, "That's a late symptom, and you may be in the early stages. What you need is a glucose tolerance test."

That's not pleasant if you don't like having blood withdrawn, and I don't.

You come in fasting. Blood is withdrawn and tested for glucose content. It should be within certain normal limits. You are then forced to drink a large jug of glucose solution, which is sort of sickly sweet. Glucose is the natural sugar of blood, and if you drink it, it is at once absorbed into the blood, the glucose content of which shoots sky-high.

If you're normal, the shock of the glucose entry stimulates the production of insulin, which promotes the conversion of the glucose into a form of starch called glycogen, which is stored in the liver. The blood glucose therefore sinks rapidly. If you are an incipient diabetic, however, the formation of insulin lags and the blood glucose sinks only slowly and doesn't reach normal levels for a long time.

Blood samples have to be withdrawn periodically and glucose content determined. A graph is drawn and from the shape of the curve one can tell whether incipient diabetes seems to be present or not.

Eventually, on November 4, 1953, I had Dr. Walker's technician perform the